

BONUS 10 OF 12

Never Ruin Another Project

Fix dropped stitches, tension issues, and common mistakes — save every project

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SECTION 1

The 10 Most Common Knitting Mistakes

Identify them before they become a problem

Every knitter — beginner or expert — makes mistakes. The difference is knowing what went wrong and how to prevent it next time.

MISTAKE	CAUSE	PREVENTION
Dropped stitch	Stitch slips off the needle unnoticed	Count stitches at the end of every row; use stitch markers
Added (extra) stitch	Accidental yarn-over or knitting into the bar between stitches	Learn to read your stitches; count regularly
Uneven tension	Grip changes as you tire or switch between knit and purl	Take breaks; practice consistent yarn wrapping
Twisted stitches	Wrapping yarn the wrong way or picking up stitches backwards	Check that the leading leg sits in front of the needle
Splitting yarn	Needle pierces the strand instead of going through the loop	Use blunter needle tips; slow down on fuzzy yarns
Wrong stitch count after cast-on	Miscounting or losing the first/last stitch	Count immediately after casting on; place a marker every 20 stitches
Holes in stockinette	Accidental yarn-overs, especially after turning	Make sure yarn is in the correct position before the first stitch of each row
Curling edges	Natural property of stockinette stitch	Add a garter or seed-stitch border; block aggressively
Joining in the round with a twist	Cast-on row spirals around the needle	Lay work flat and check alignment before joining; knit one flat row first
Miscrossed cables	Holding cable needle to the wrong side	Mark your pattern: “F” for front (left cross), “B” for back (right cross)

Golden Rule

Count your stitches at the end of every row when learning a new stitch pattern. It takes five seconds and saves hours of frogging.

SECTION 2

Fixing Dropped Stitches — Step by Step

The single most important rescue technique in knitting

A dropped stitch looks terrifying — a ladder of loose yarn running down your fabric. But with a crochet hook and a little patience, every dropped stitch can be rescued.

Picking Up a Dropped Knit Stitch

- 1 **Locate the dropped stitch** and gently spread the work so you can see the horizontal ladder of yarn strands above it.
- 2 **Insert a crochet hook** (same size or one size smaller than your needles) **front to back** through the live loop of the dropped stitch.
- 3 **Catch the lowest horizontal strand** with the hook and pull it through the loop. You have now “climbed” one rung of the ladder.
- 4 **Repeat for every rung** until you reach the current row.
- 5 **Place the rescued stitch back on the left needle**, making sure it is not twisted — the leading leg should sit in front of the needle.

Picking Up a Dropped Purl Stitch

- 1 **Turn your work** so the purl side faces you. The purl bump should be coming toward you.
- 2 **Insert the crochet hook back to front** through the dropped loop.
- 3 **Grab the horizontal strand from behind** the stitch and pull it through the loop toward you.
- 4 **Continue up every rung.** If your pattern alternates knit and purl columns (like ribbing), flip the work each time the stitch type changes.
- 5 **Return the stitch to the left needle**, untwisted.

Watch Out

If the dropped stitch has run down more than a few rows, insert a locking stitch marker or safety pin through the live loop immediately to stop it from unraveling further while you work.

SECTION 3

Tension Problems and How to Fix Them

Achieve smooth, even fabric every time

Tension — how tightly or loosely you hold the yarn — is the single biggest factor in the look and drape of your finished knitting.

Too Tight

Stitches are hard to slide along the needle. Fabric feels stiff and smaller than expected. Your hands ache after a few rows. **Fix:** Go up one or two needle sizes. Consciously push each new stitch onto the wider part of the needle before starting the next. Relax your grip — the yarn should flow, not be squeezed.

Too Loose

Fabric looks “holey” and sloppy. Gauge swatch is larger than the pattern calls for. Stitches slide around freely. **Fix:** Go down one or two needle sizes. Wrap the yarn around one more finger to add friction. Tug gently on the working yarn after completing each stitch.

Just Right

Stitches glide smoothly along the needle with light pressure. Fabric has an even appearance and matches your gauge swatch. The leading leg of every stitch sits neatly in front of the needle.

Tension Exercises

- 1 The Swatch Ladder:** Knit a 30-stitch swatch in stockinette. After every 10 rows, switch needle sizes (one size up, then one size down). Compare the sections to see how needle size affects your personal tension.
- 2 The Timer Test:** Set a timer for 15 minutes and knit at a relaxed pace. Count your rows. Now knit for another 15 minutes at your “normal” speed. If the stitch size changes noticeably, your tension varies with speed — slow down until it stabilizes.
- 3 Continental vs. English:** If you struggle with tension in your current style, try the other method. Many tight English-style knitters find continental loosens them up, and vice versa.

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The Finger Wrap: Experiment with wrapping the yarn around different fingers. More wraps = more friction = tighter tension. Find the wrap that gives you a smooth, consistent flow.

SECTION 4

Reading Your Knitting — How to Spot Errors Early

Catch mistakes in the row they happen, not 20 rows later

Learning to “read” your knitting means understanding what each stitch looks like so you can spot a problem the moment it appears.

Knit Stitch (Right Side)

Looks like a small **V**. The two legs should be smooth, even, and all leaning the same way. A twisted stitch will have crossed legs instead of an open V.

Purl Stitch (Wrong Side)

Looks like a horizontal **bump** or a tiny necklace. Bumps should be uniform in size. An extra-large bump may indicate a yarn-over mistake.

Dropped Stitch

A visible **ladder** of horizontal strands running down the fabric, with a live loop at the bottom. The sooner you spot it, the fewer rungs you need to climb.

Accidental Yarn-Over

An **extra hole** in the fabric with a strand draped over the needle that should not be there. It creates an unwanted eyelet. Remove it by dropping it off the needle on the next row.

Twisted Stitch

The stitch sits on the needle with the **trailing leg in front** instead of behind. The resulting stitch looks tighter and slightly angled compared to its neighbors.

Split Stitch

The needle went through **part of the yarn strand** instead of the whole loop. Looks fuzzy or doubled. Fix by tinking back to the split stitch and re-knitting it properly.

Habit to Build

After every row, glance across your needle. Do all stitches look the same? Is the count right? This two-second check will save you from discovering a mistake ten rows later.

SECTION 5

Frogging and Tinking Without Tears

When you need to rip back — do it safely

“Frogging” (rip-it, rip-it) means pulling out rows of knitting. “Tinking” (knit spelled backwards) means un-knitting one stitch at a time. Both are essential skills.

Tinking — Undo One Stitch at a Time

- 1 **Insert the left needle front to back** into the stitch below the one on the right needle.
- 2 **Slide the right needle out** of the current stitch and gently pull the working yarn to undo it.
- 3 **The stitch is now safely on the left needle.** Repeat until you reach the mistake.
- 4 **Fix the error** and resume knitting forward.

Frogging — Ripping Back Multiple Rows

- 1 **Insert a lifeline first** (see below) one row below where you want to stop, if possible.
- 2 **Slide the work off the needles.** Take a breath.
- 3 **Gently pull the working yarn** to unravel. Go slowly — yanking can tangle and stretch the yarn.
- 4 **Stop one row above your lifeline** (or target row). Carefully slide the needle back through the live stitches, checking that none are twisted.
- 5 **Count your stitches** to confirm the correct number before resuming.

The Lifeline Technique

What Is a Lifeline?

A lifeline is a length of smooth, thin yarn (or dental floss) threaded through every stitch on your needle at a known “good” row. If you need to frog, you can rip back confidently to the lifeline — every stitch is held safely. Insert a new lifeline every 10–20 rows on complex patterns. Some circular needles have a lifeline hole in the join for exactly this purpose.

SECTION 6

Fixing Mistakes Without Ripping

Targeted repairs that save your time and sanity

Not every mistake requires frogging. These techniques let you fix individual stitches in place.

The Duplicate Stitch Fix

- 1 Thread a **tapestry needle** with a length of the same yarn.
- 2 Find the **stitch you want to cover** on the right side of the fabric. Insert the needle under both legs of the stitch in the row above the mistake.
- 3 Insert the **needle back through the base** of the same stitch (where the two legs of the V meet).
- 4 Pull **gently** to match the tension of the surrounding stitches. The duplicate stitch now sits on top of the error, hiding it completely.
- 5 **Perfect for colorwork:** you can “paint” the correct color over the wrong one without ripping a single row.

The Ladder-Down Fix (Intentional Drop)

- 1 Identify the **column** containing the mistake. Work to that column on the current row.
- 2 Deliberately **drop the stitch** off the needle and let it ladder down to the row where the error is.
- 3 Use a **crochet hook** to pick the stitch back up correctly, working each rung of the ladder in the proper pattern (knit or purl as needed).
- 4 Place the **corrected stitch back on the needle** and continue.
- 5 **Ideal for single wrong stitches** (knit where you should have purled, or vice versa) several rows back.

When NOT to Use These Techniques

If the mistake involves the wrong stitch count (added or lost stitches), you must tink or frog back to the error row. Duplicate stitch and ladder fixes only work when the number of stitches is correct but one or more are the wrong type or color.

SECTION 7

Blocking and Finishing Fixes

The final step that transforms handmade into professional

Blocking evens out tension, opens up lace, and brings your knitting to its final shape and size. It fixes an astonishing number of “mistakes” that are really just unfinished fabric.

METHOD	BEST FOR	HOW TO
Wet blocking	Wool, alpaca, cotton — most natural fibers	Soak in lukewarm water for 20 minutes. Gently squeeze (never wring). Lay flat on blocking mats, pin to measurements, let dry completely.
Steam blocking	Wool blends, pieces that need quick shaping	Pin piece to measurements. Hold steam iron 2–3 cm above the fabric (never touch). Let steam penetrate and cool before removing pins.
Spray blocking	Delicate fibers, items that should not be fully submerged	Pin to shape. Spritz thoroughly with a spray bottle. Pat gently to even out moisture. Let dry.
Killing acrylic	100% acrylic yarn (permanent — cannot be undone)	Pin to shape. Apply steam iron very lightly. The fiber softens and “melts” into its final drape. Test on a swatch first.

Finishing Steps

Post-Knitting Finishing Checklist

- ☐ Weave in all yarn tails (minimum 2 inches woven, changing direction at least once)
- ☐ Seam pieces together using mattress stitch for invisible joins
- ☐ Block the assembled piece to final measurements
- ☐ Check all buttons, snaps, or zippers are securely attached
- ☐ Trim any remaining yarn tails flush with the fabric surface
- ☐ Give the piece a final steam or press if needed after seaming
- ☐ Compare finished measurements to the pattern schematic

Blocking Fixes These “Mistakes”

Slightly uneven tension, curling stockinette edges, lace that looks bunched up, colorwork that looks puckered, and pieces that are a little too small. Always block before deciding something is ruined.

SECTION 8

Emergency Repair Kit

Everything you need to save any project, anywhere

Keep this kit in your project bag and you will never be caught off guard by a knitting emergency.

Essential Repair Tools

- ☐ Crochet hooks in 3 sizes (one smaller, one matching, one larger than your needles)
- ☐ Locking stitch markers (at least 10 — use as emergency stitch holders)
- ☐ Tapestry needles (blunt tip, two sizes)
- ☐ Small sharp scissors or a yarn cutter pendant
- ☐ Smooth cotton yarn or dental floss for lifelines
- ☐ Spare double-pointed needle in your project size (for cable repairs)
- ☐ Row counter (mechanical click counter or app)
- ☐ Measuring tape
- ☐ Safety pins (large, for holding dropped stitches)
- ☐ Sticky notes and a pen (for marking your place in a pattern)

Pro Tips

Keep a photocopy or screenshot of your pattern's key page in your project bag — phones die, but paper does not. Slip a lifeline through your work every time you complete a repeat of a complex pattern. And remember: every expert knitter has frogged entire projects. Mistakes are not failures — they are proof that you are learning.

Quick-Reference Decision Tree

Stitch Count Is Wrong

Added a stitch? Find the accidental yarn-over and drop it off the needle, or tink back to the error.

Lost a stitch? Look for a dropped stitch ladder. Pick it up with a crochet hook.

Stitch Count Is Correct

Wrong stitch type? Use the ladder-down fix to drop and re-knit the single column.

Wrong color? Use duplicate stitch to embroider the correct color over the mistake.

Fabric Looks Uneven

Block first. At least 80% of uneven-looking fabric is fixed by proper wet blocking. Judge only after blocking.

Major Structural Error

Insert a lifeline at the last good row. Frog confidently to that point. Re-count stitches and resume.

Next Step

You now have the tools to rescue any knitting project from any mistake. Keep this guide in your project bag and refer to it whenever something goes wrong.

Return to The Ultimate Knitting Library to continue building your skills with the next bonus guide.